

Briefing IV — The Journey Begins: Brittany & Normandy

Where We Are: Brittany

The adventure finally begins.

After months of planning, countless emails, reservations, and more than a few family discussions, we'll all find ourselves together in France.

Our first day won't be filled with museums or famous landmarks.

Instead, it will be spent doing something equally important.

We'll simply make our way across the French countryside.

After picking up our rental cars at Charles de Gaulle Airport, we'll head west for about four and a half hours toward Brittany, one of France's most distinctive regions.

As we leave the busy suburbs of Paris behind and the highways give way to smaller roads, you'll probably notice that France doesn't feel quite the way you imagined.

Rather than endless cities, we'll pass rolling farmland, stone farmhouses, tidy villages, church steeples, and fields divided by ancient hedgerows.

Much of this landscape has changed remarkably little over the centuries.

This is a working countryside, where agriculture remains an important part of everyday life and villages are still the center of their local communities.

Let's all keep the phones and screens away. Take in the surroundings.

Tonight, we're not checking into a hotel.

We're beginning our trip with something much more personal.

We'll be staying with the Ferradinis near Rennes, giving us a chance to experience everyday French family life before our sightseeing really begins.

I can't imagine a better way to start the journey.

Before we visit famous monuments or walk through medieval villages, we'll simply share an evening with friends around a dinner table.

That's a reminder that every great trip is ultimately about people as much as places.

After a good night's sleep—and hopefully a little help from the fresh air to overcome the jet lag—we'll set out for one of the most extraordinary places in all of Europe: Mont Saint-Michel.

But for today, there's really only one job.

Stay awake.

Take in the scenery.

Enjoy the drive.

And savor that wonderful feeling that after all the planning, after months of anticipation...we're finally here.

Mont Saint-Michel: The Wonder of the West

Our first full day in France takes us to one of the country's most iconic places.

Mont Saint-Michel.

It's difficult to describe the feeling of seeing it for the first time.

Long before we arrive, we'll begin to notice something unusual on the horizon.

Rising seemingly out of nowhere, the abbey appears almost to float above the surrounding landscape.

It's one of those rare places that somehow manages to exceed the photographs.

The story begins more than 1,300 years ago.

According to tradition, the Archangel Michael appeared to Aubert, the Bishop of Avranches, and instructed him to build a church on this rocky island. Aubert was reportedly a bit skeptical, and legend says Saint Michael eventually persuaded him by pressing a finger into his skull. Whether or not you believe the story, the church was built, and over the centuries it grew into one of the greatest pilgrimage destinations in medieval Europe.

For hundreds of years, pilgrims walked for miles across the tidal flats to reach the abbey. They came seeking forgiveness, healing, or simply the chance to worship in one of Christianity's most extraordinary settings.

Today we'll take a much easier route.

But as we make the walk from the parking area toward the island, it's worth imagining what it must have felt like to see the abbey slowly growing larger with every step.

One of the remarkable things about Mont Saint-Michel is that it was never chosen simply because it was beautiful.

It was chosen because it was dramatic.

The tides here are among the largest in Europe. At high tide, the island was surrounded by water, offering natural protection. At low tide, vast stretches of sand emerged, creating an ever-changing landscape that was beautiful but also dangerous for anyone unfamiliar with it.

That natural fortress proved invaluable during the Hundred Years' War. Although much of Normandy fell under English control, Mont Saint-Michel never did. It withstood repeated sieges and became a powerful symbol of French resilience.

As we climb through the narrow medieval streets toward the abbey, we'll notice how the village seems to grow out of the rock itself.

The homes, shops, and inns weren't built as tourist attractions.

They were built to serve generations of pilgrims who passed through these gates long before any of us arrived.

Eventually we'll reach the abbey at the summit.

Take a moment before looking at the details.

Simply look out.

To one side, the sea.

To the other, an immense expanse of tidal flats stretching toward the horizon.

It's easy to understand why medieval visitors believed this was a place where heaven and earth felt just a little closer together.

After our visit, we'll stop for something much less medieval but equally French.

We'll pick up sandwiches from a local boulangerie and enjoy a simple picnic as we continue east toward Normandy.

Our destination this afternoon couldn't be more different from the place we're leaving.

We'll arrive at the Normandy American Cemetery just before the day's flag-lowering ceremony.

After spending the morning surrounded by more than a thousand years of history, we'll suddenly find ourselves standing in a place where the events feel almost within living memory.

We'll save that story for our next section.

For now, simply know that it's one of the most moving places in France, and one that has become sacred ground for both Americans and the French.

After the ceremony, we'll make the short drive to Bayeux.

That medieval town will be our home for the night—a quiet place to walk, share dinner together, and reflect on everything we've experienced during our first full day in France.

Tomorrow we'll return to Normandy's beaches, cliffs, and villages to better understand the events that unfolded here in June of 1944 before continuing on to Paris.

One final suggestion before we leave Mont Saint-Michel.

Spend a few minutes looking back.

As the abbey grows smaller in the distance, you'll understand why travelers have been remembering this place for more than a thousand years.

The Normandy American Cemetery: A Place of Remembrance

On this afternoon we'll visit a place unlike any other on our journey.

The Normandy American Cemetery.

There are beautiful places in France.

There are historic places.

There are inspiring places.

This is a sacred place.

More than 9,300 American servicemen and women are buried here, overlooking Omaha Beach.

Most were very young.

Many were not much older than Tommy and Sam are today.

Some were younger than that.

As we walk among the rows of white marble crosses and Stars of David, one thing quickly becomes apparent.

Every headstone represents a person.

Someone's son.

Someone's brother.

Someone's husband.

Someone's father.

Someone whose story ended here, far from home, so that others might live in freedom.

We'll arrive in time for the afternoon flag-lowering ceremony.

It's a simple ceremony.

There is no spectacle.

No elaborate production.

Just a few quiet minutes that remind us this isn't simply a historic site.

It's a cemetery.

As Americans, it's difficult not to feel a connection to this place.

But one of the remarkable things about the Normandy American Cemetery is that it also speaks to the friendship between our two countries.

The land beneath our feet was given by France to the United States as a permanent resting place for those who never came home.

It's one of the most enduring symbols of the bond between our nations.

As we stand here, it's worth looking beyond the cemetery itself.

Just below us lies Omaha Beach.

On June 6, 1944, thousands of young Americans crossed that stretch of water under unimaginably difficult circumstances.

Many never made it beyond the sand.

Tomorrow we'll walk some of those same beaches.

We'll visit the cliffs at Pointe du Hoc.

We'll stand beside the German gun batteries at Longues-sur-Mer.

We'll visit Sainte-Mère-Église, one of the first French towns liberated on D-Day.

Today, though, isn't about understanding the battle.

It's about remembering the people.

There's no right way to experience a place like this.

Some people will walk quietly.

Some may read names.

Some may simply look out toward the sea.

Whatever you do, take your time.

History isn't only found in books.

Sometimes it's found in silence.

And I suspect that years from now, when we think back on this trip, this quiet hillside overlooking Omaha Beach may be one of the places we remember most.

D-Day: The Longest Day

We'll spend much of the next day exploring the beaches, villages, and battlefields that became forever linked with one date:

June 6, 1944.

D-Day.

It's difficult to overstate the importance of what happened here.

By the spring of 1944, much of Western Europe had been under Nazi occupation for nearly four years. Millions of people had seen their freedoms disappear, and the Allied nations knew that liberating France would require the largest amphibious invasion ever attempted.

After years of planning—and an extraordinary deception campaign that convinced the Germans the invasion would come elsewhere—more than 150,000 Allied troops crossed the English Channel during the night and early morning of June 6.

They came from many nations.

Americans.

British.

Canadians.

Free French forces.

And soldiers from across the Allied world.

Thousands of ships filled the Channel.

More than 11,000 aircraft flew overhead.

Before dawn, American and British paratroopers dropped behind enemy lines to seize bridges, block reinforcements, and create confusion. Many landed miles from their intended targets, yet

small groups of soldiers adapted, found one another, and continued their missions under incredibly difficult circumstances.

As the sun began to rise, the first landing craft reached the beaches.

The code names have since become part of history: Utah, Omaha, Gold, Juno, and Sword.

Each beach had its own story.

Each demanded extraordinary courage.

For Americans, Omaha Beach has become the defining image of D-Day. Strong German defenses, steep bluffs, and relentless fire made it the bloodiest landing of the invasion. Units became scattered, officers were lost, and carefully prepared plans unraveled almost immediately.

Yet small groups of soldiers continued moving forward.

They climbed the bluffs.

Found gaps in the defenses.

Helped one another.

And slowly, yard by yard, opened the way inland.

As we stand on those cliffs and look out across the Channel, it's also worth taking a moment to imagine what the young German soldiers must have seen.

Many were barely out of their teens.

Some had been stationed in Normandy for months, waiting and wondering when—or if—the invasion would come.

Then, as dawn broke on June 6, the horizon filled with more ships than they could have imagined.

They were fighting for a regime whose ideology brought unimaginable suffering to Europe and the world, and that cause deserves neither admiration nor celebration.

But the young men themselves were human beings, many frightened, many far from home, and many destined to die on those same cliffs and beaches.

Recognizing their humanity doesn't diminish the courage or sacrifice of the Allied soldiers.

If anything, it reminds us of the true tragedy of war—that so often it is the young on every side who bear its greatest cost.

History often celebrates great commanders, but Normandy reminds us that history is also changed by ordinary people making extraordinary decisions under impossible circumstances.

Teachers.

Farm boys.

Factory workers.

College students.

Men who only months earlier had been living everyday American lives.

Many had never traveled farther from home than a neighboring state.

Now they found themselves on a beach in France, carrying the weight of history on their shoulders.

By the end of June 6, the Allies had secured a fragile foothold in Normandy.

The cost was staggering, but the invasion had succeeded.

From those beaches, the liberation of France began.

Less than three months later, Paris was free.

Less than a year later, the war in Europe was over.

Tomorrow, as we stand on those beaches, it's worth remembering that history rarely feels inevitable while it's happening.

The people who came ashore that morning didn't know how the story would end.

They only knew what was expected of them in that moment.

Perhaps that's one of the enduring lessons of Normandy.

History isn't shaped only by famous leaders.

Sometimes it's changed by ordinary people who simply refuse to give up.

As we visit Omaha Beach, Pointe du Hoc, Longues-sur-Mer, and Sainte-Mère-Église, I hope we'll keep that thought with us.

The places we'll see are remarkable in their own right.

But it's the courage, sacrifice, and determination they represent that have made them unforgettable.

Walking Normandy

As we explore these sacred battlefields, history will become something we can actually see.

Not on the pages of a book.

Not in a documentary.

But beneath our feet.

We'll begin at Omaha Beach.

At first glance, it may surprise you.

It's beautiful.

A broad stretch of sand.

Gentle waves rolling onto shore.

Families walking the beach.

Children building sandcastles.

It's almost impossible to reconcile that peaceful scene with what happened here on the morning of June 6, 1944.

Stand quietly for a moment.

Look from the water toward the bluffs.

Then imagine trying to cross that open beach under enemy fire.

Distances that seem manageable suddenly feel impossibly long.

Next we'll visit Pointe du Hoc.

When you first arrive, the landscape looks almost lunar.

Enormous bomb craters still scar the ground.

The bunkers remain.

The cliffs are every bit as steep as they appear in the photographs.

It was here that U.S. Army Rangers climbed nearly one hundred feet of sheer cliff under fire to silence German guns that threatened the invasion beaches.

Standing there, it's difficult not to wonder what kind of courage that required.

At Longues-sur-Mer, we'll see one of the best-preserved German artillery batteries in Normandy.

The massive concrete gun emplacements remain, still facing the sea.

Walk inside one of those bunkers if you have the opportunity.

Look out through the narrow openings toward the English Channel.

It's from places like these that I first began thinking about the young German soldiers who waited there.

Not to honor the cause they served, but to appreciate the terrible human reality of war.

Imagine watching the largest invasion fleet in history slowly emerge from the morning mist, knowing that within hours your own life—and countless others—would be forever changed.

Finally, we'll visit Sainte-Mère-Église.

If you've ever seen photographs of a parachute hanging from a church steeple, you've seen this town.

During the airborne landings, paratrooper John Steele became caught on the church tower and famously survived by pretending to be dead until he was captured.

It's an extraordinary story, but it's also a reminder that history is often remembered through individual moments and remarkable acts of courage.

As we move from one site to another, I hope we'll resist the temptation to think of Normandy as a collection of tourist attractions.

Instead, think of it as one story told across an entire landscape.

Every beach.

Every hedgerow.

Every village.

Every cemetery.

Every bunker.

Each helps tell the story of what happened here during those remarkable days in June 1944.

While visiting Normandy, we will be staying in the village of Bayeux.

Founded by the Romans and later made famous by the Bayeux Tapestry—a remarkable 230-foot embroidered chronicle of William the Conqueror's Norman invasion of England in 1066—

Bayeux reminds us that history here didn't begin with D-Day; it has been unfolding for nearly two thousand years.

After everything we've seen, I hope you'll take some time simply to wander.

Walk the narrow medieval streets.

Find a café.

Browse a small shop.

Sit in the cathedral square for a few minutes.

Bayeux was the first major French town liberated after D-Day, yet somehow it escaped the destruction that devastated so much of Normandy.

Its survival feels symbolic.

War passed nearby.

Life endured.

And today the town quietly reminds us what all those young men—Allied and German alike—were fighting, and dying, among.

Not beaches.

Not bunkers.

But ordinary places where people could once again live in peace.

As we leave Normandy for Paris, I suspect we'll carry more than photographs with us.

We'll carry a deeper appreciation for the cost of freedom, the resilience of those who rebuilt afterward, and the enduring friendship between France and the United States that was forged here more than eighty years ago.